

The future of work

OLOF SCHYBERGSON | JUNE 11 2026



This is what the work transition feels like

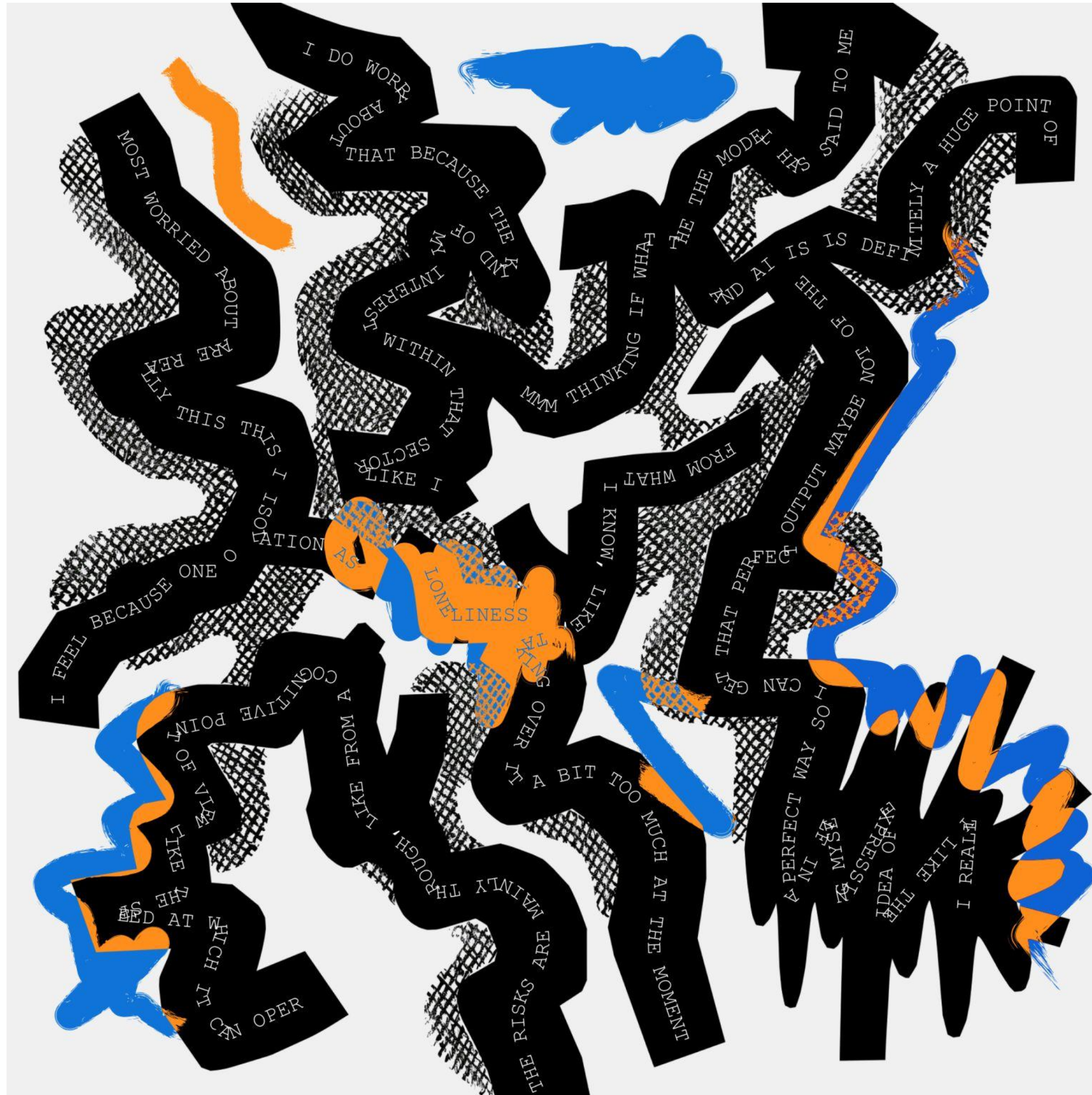


In a week there'll be three more tools I need to learn. And two I've already learned – you don't need those anymore.

*I'm learning how to make things work.
Not how they work.*

People aren't interested in their projects anymore. It was different only a year ago.

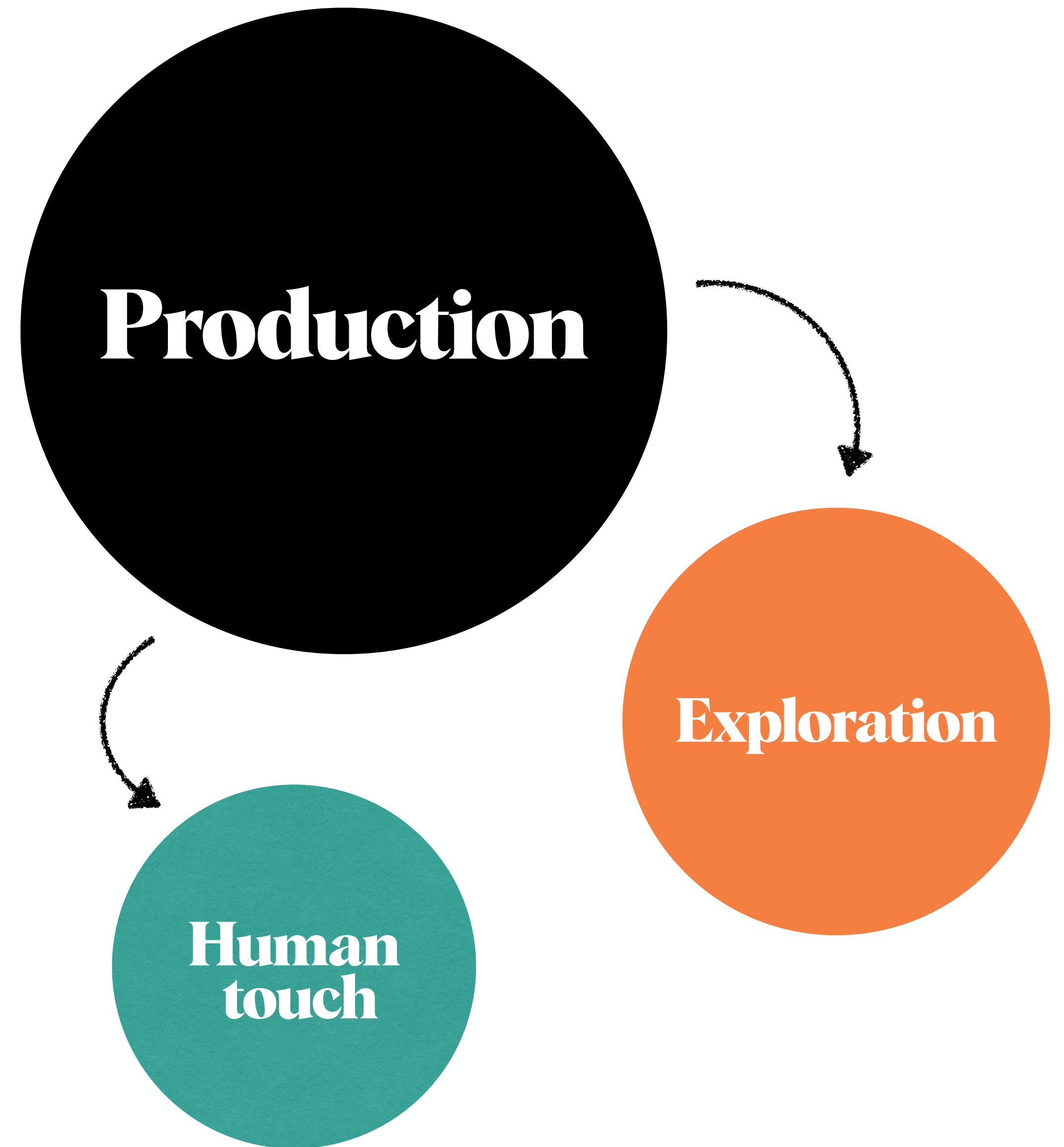
I'll use my passion elsewhere if it's not wanted at work.



"AI and Work – How Young People Are Thinking About the Future"
by Mark Curtis, Full Moon

AI changes what **humans** should focus on

The human's role will shift from industrialised office work, toward exploratory work, plus human-centered real-world work.



Play is not the opposite
of work.

It is the
foundation of it.

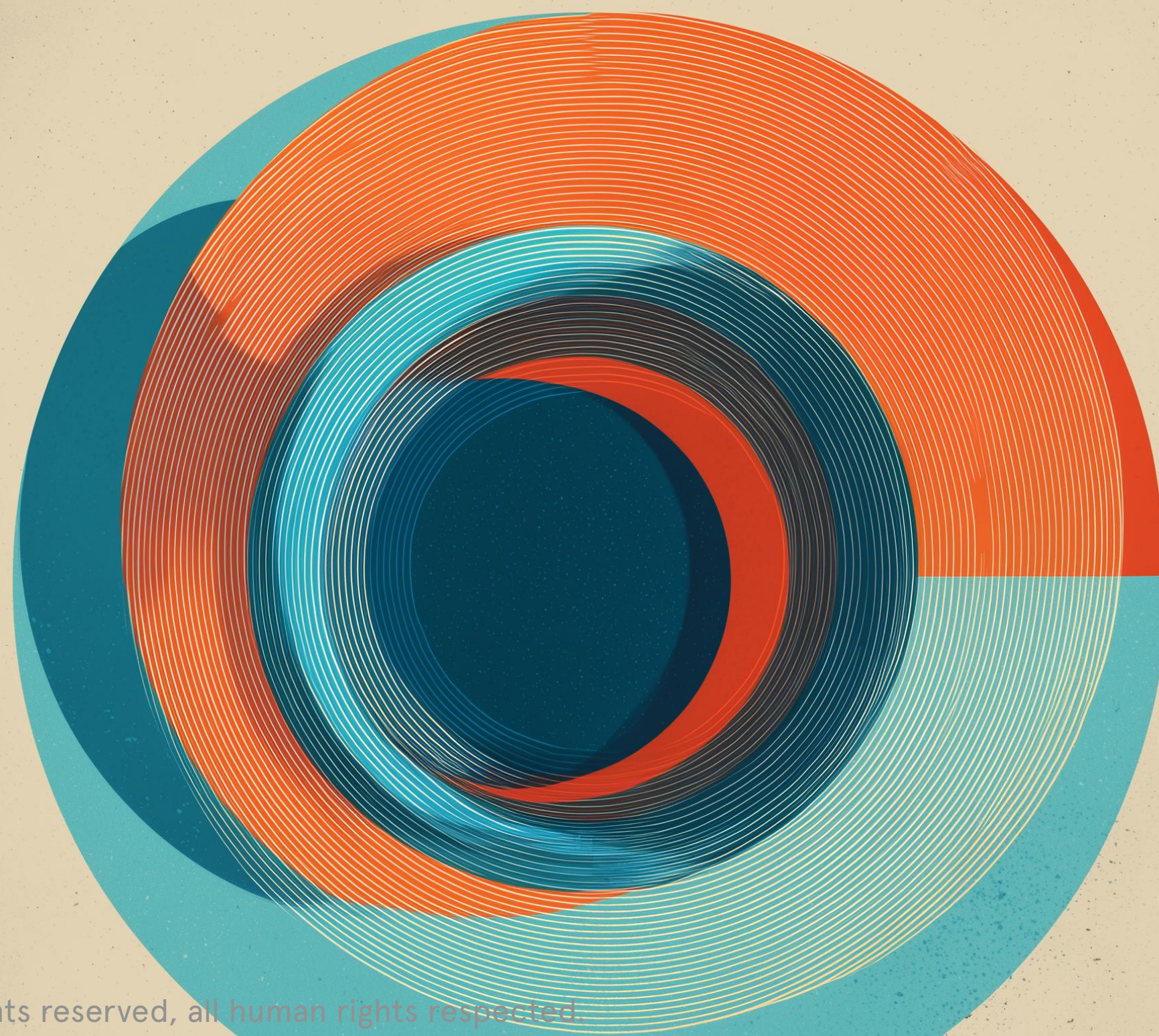
The Fjord Story

Started in London in 2001.
Grew to 4,000 people, 35 studios.
Acquired by Accenture in 2013.

The question we kept asking: what are the conditions that consistently produce work that matters?



One word kept coming back



After 25 years of building, Mark Curtis and I sat down to figure out what we'd actually been doing.

We read the research. We interviewed 40 leaders. We argued about it over tennis, saunas, and long dinners.

And gradually, one word kept surfacing. Not as a metaphor, but as the most accurate description of the conditions that had consistently produced our best work.

Play

The future of work is Play



Play is how we learn, adapt, and invent. It is our oldest and most powerful mode of creative thinking.

In an AI-augmented world, where optimisation is increasingly automated, play is not a luxury. It is the primary human competitive advantage.

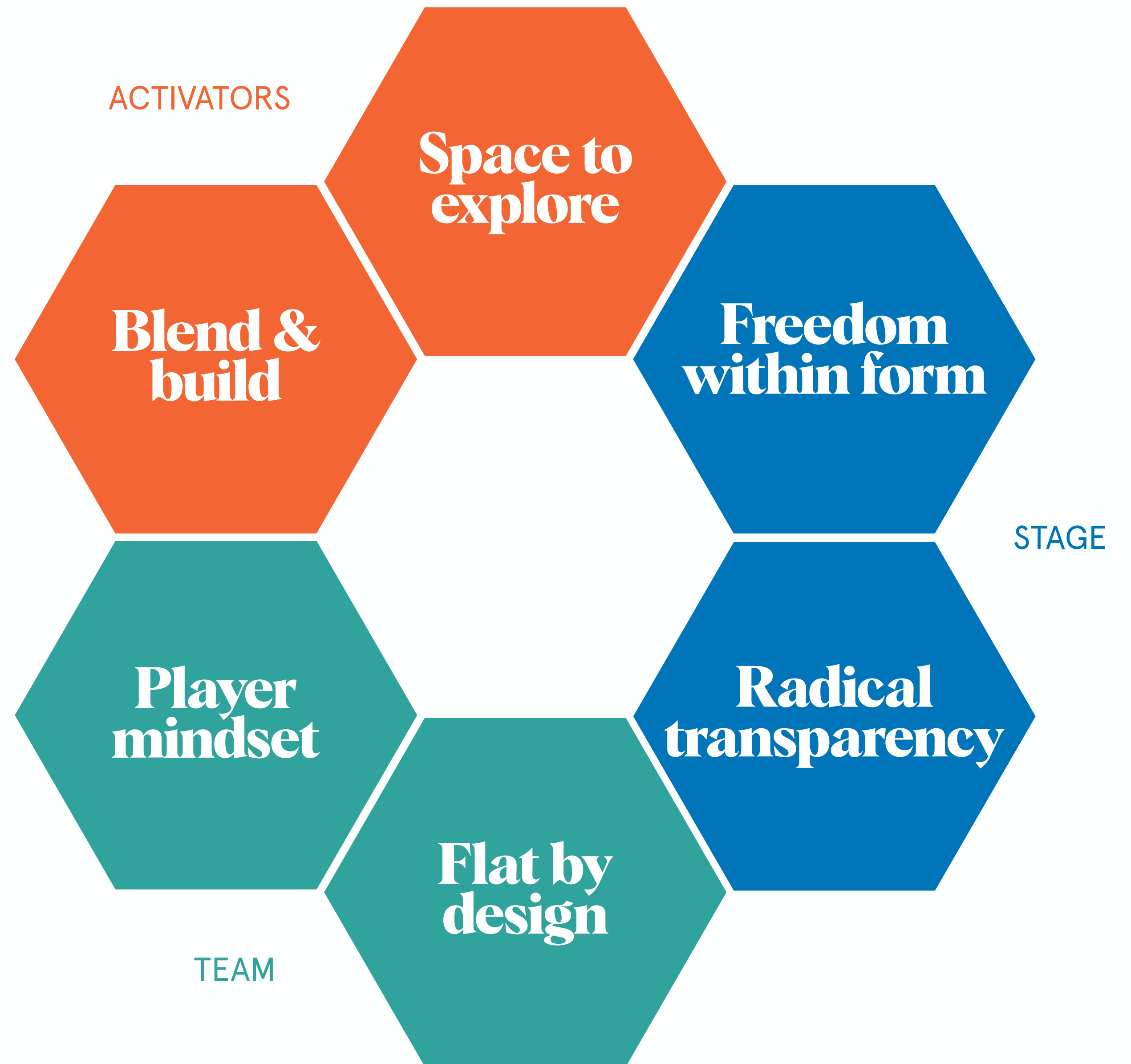
The background is a stylized illustration of a night landscape. In the foreground, two silhouetted figures stand on a rocky outcrop, looking out over a city at night. The city lights are visible in the valley below, with a prominent red light source, possibly a lighthouse or a fire, illuminating the scene. The mountains in the background are dark and silhouetted against a dark, cloudy sky. The overall color palette is dark, with blues, greys, and oranges from the city lights and the word 'not' in the text.

Play is **not** always fun. Play is **not** the opposite of work.

It is serious. It is goal-oriented. It is how jazz musicians improvise, how scientists generate breakthroughs, how great design teams do their best work.

We're talking about applied, adult play — drawing from childhood play, from sport, from creative practice. Not bean bags.

The Play⁺ model: six universal essentials



THE PLAY+ MODEL

Player mindset

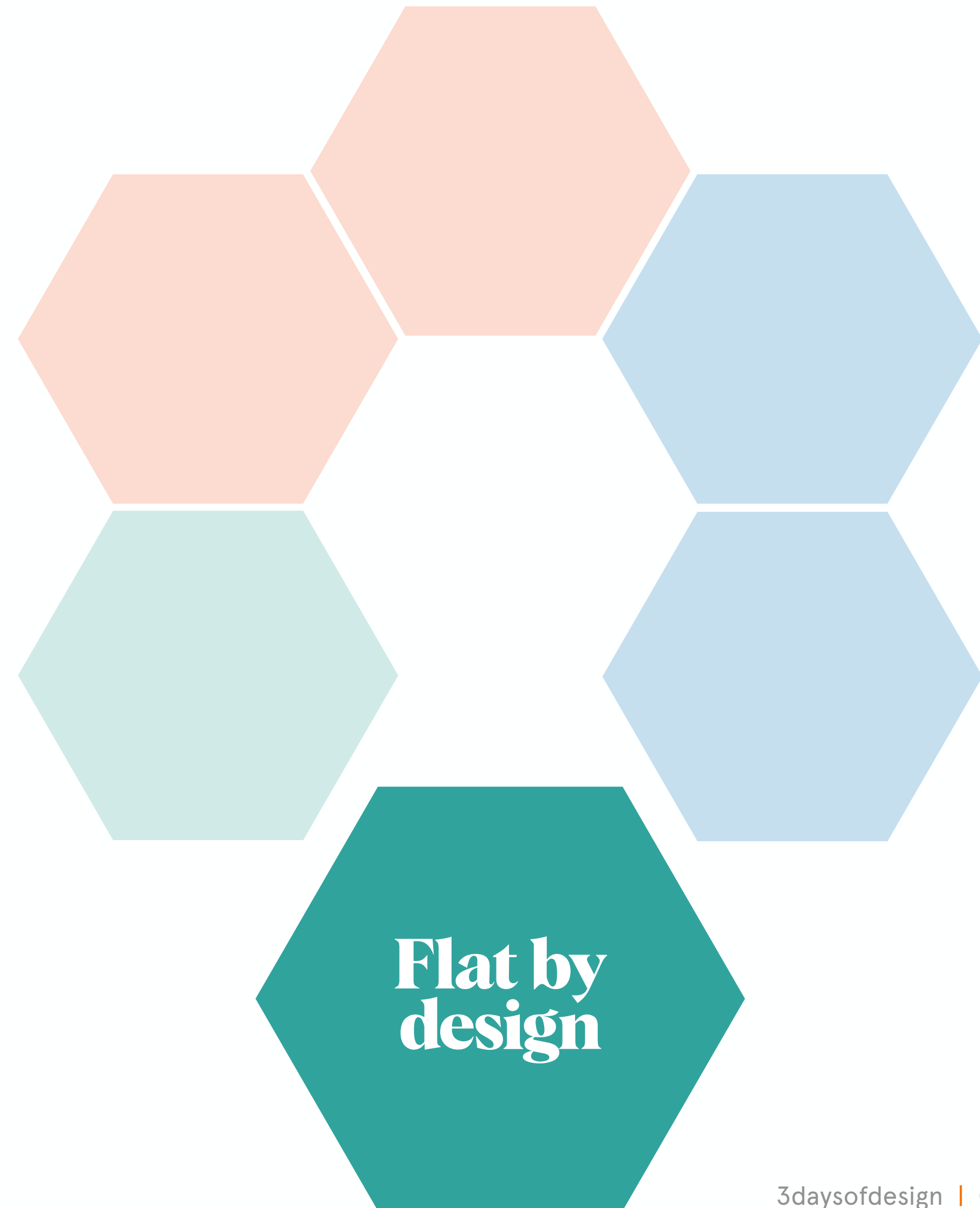
Everyone comes with a collaborative spirit and a genuine willingness to contribute. The magic of play requires people who are truly in the game. Not spectators, not passengers.



THE PLAY+ MODEL

Flat by design

Hierarchy is suspended during play. Ideas win on merit, not seniority. The most junior person in the room can have the best idea, and the best environments make that possible.



THE PLAY+ MODEL

Radical transparency

Information flows freely in all directions: no hoarding, no monopolies, no knowledge kept as power. Good ideas emerge when inspiration, information, and perspectives can meet and combine.



THE PLAY+ MODEL

Freedom within form

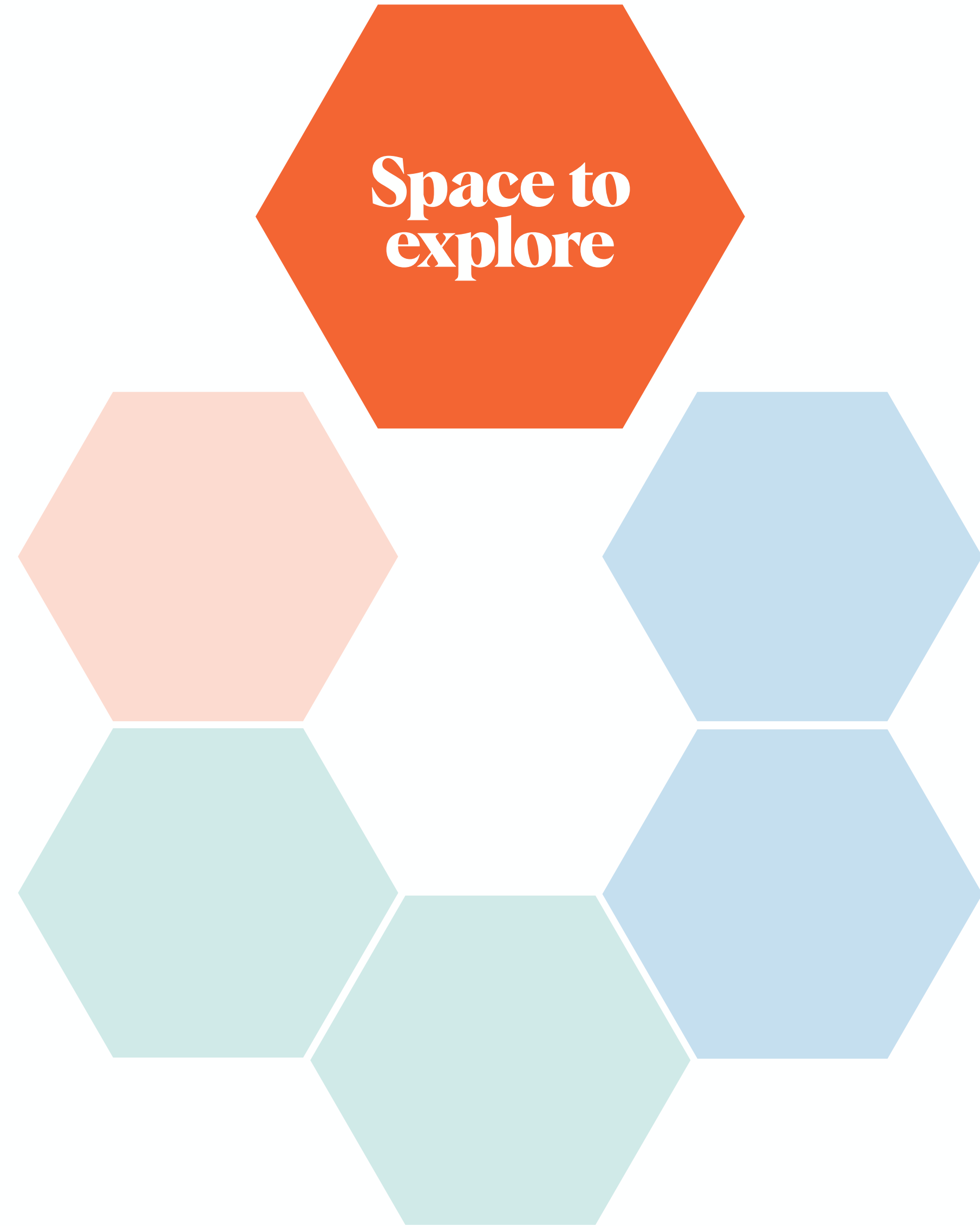
Clear boundaries and rules, but
genuine autonomy within them.
Structure enables freedom rather
than constraining it. The playground
has edges, but inside those edges,
people self-organise and direct their
own contribution.



THE PLAY+ MODEL

Space to explore

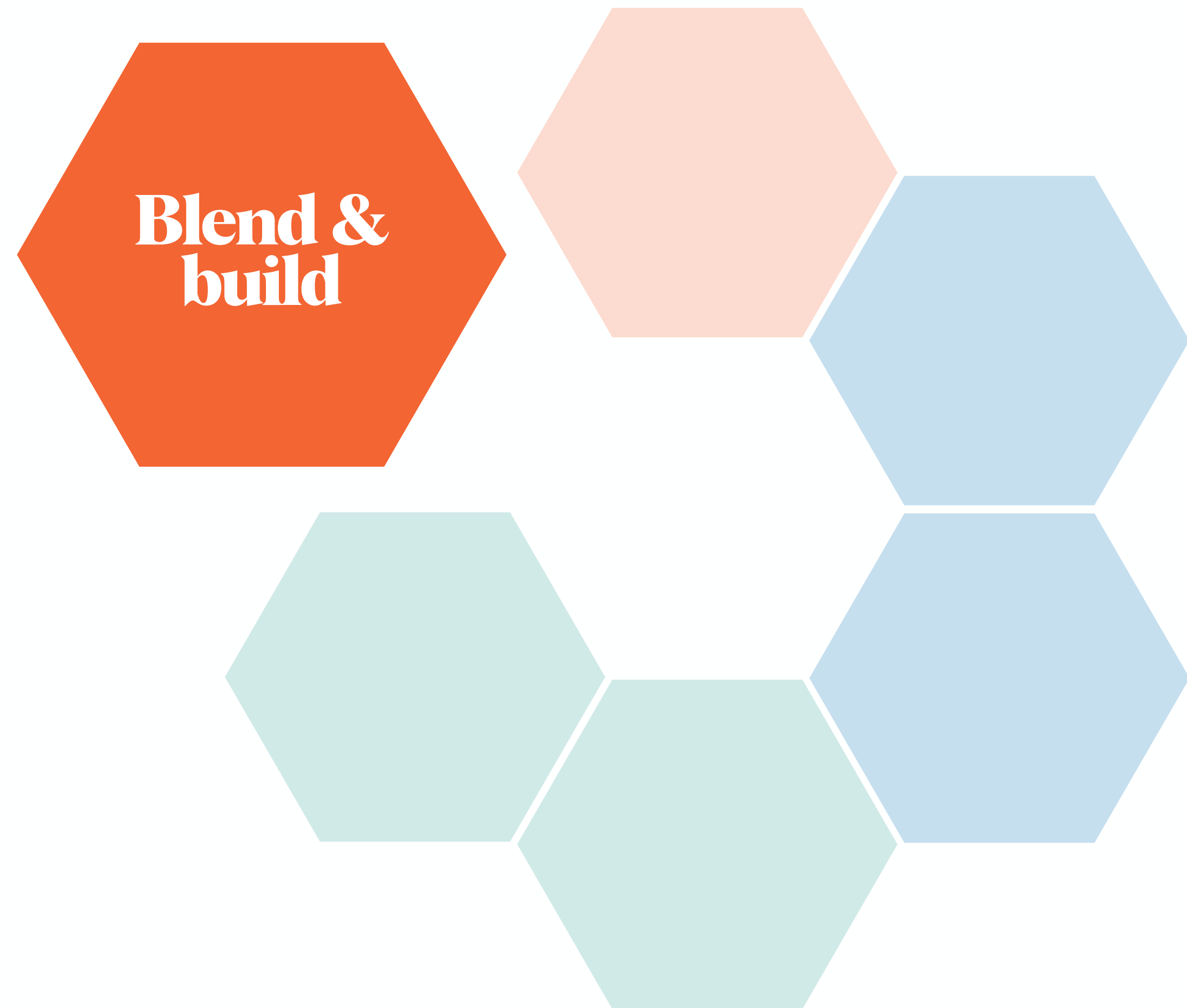
Dedicated time for exploration and experimentation, not just delivery.
Great solutions need room to breathe.
Treating discarded ideas as learning opportunities rather than failures.



THE PLAY+ MODEL

Blend & Build

Breakthrough ideas emerge from the collision of different disciplines, perspectives, and domains. Diverse teams generate genuinely novel solutions. Combining things that don't obviously belong together generates breakthroughs.



What this looks like in practice: Changi Airport DIVA



THE CHALLENGE

How do you innovate at startup speed while running one of the world's busiest airports?

THE CONFIGURATION

Cross-functional teams, information flowing freely, real autonomy within clear operational boundaries, building and testing real products rather than writing plans

THE CONTEXT

Live operational environment, real consequences, no room for chaos

THE RESULT

Digital usage up 40%, passenger satisfaction up 5 points – and a team that felt genuinely energised by the work



Group action

A: Map org against essentials. Which is the #1 warehouse condition?

B: In a new design lead role in a large corporation, which 3 conditions will you enable first? Why?

Your *activity*

3daysofdesign
Copenhagen 11 June

ASSIGNMENT A
Playground or warehouse?
Map your own organisation against the six essentials. For each: present, partial, or absent? Identify the one essential most absent — your biggest warehouse condition. What would it take to shift it?
OUTPUT → ONE NAMED WAREHOUSE CONDITION

ASSIGNMENT B
Design the conditions
You're a new design leader joining a large bank, government dept, or law firm. You have 90 days and the CEO's goodwill. Using the six essentials as your design brief: which three conditions do you create first, and why?
OUTPUT → THREE CONDITIONS + FIRST MOVE EACH

» The question isn't whether play belongs in business. The question is whether you can afford not to intentionally design for it. — *The Future of Work is Play*



The six essentials build the playground.

The “+” is your game.

Every playground has the same basic equipment.
But no two games are the same.

The six essentials create the conditions for
breakthrough. What you do inside those conditions
— how you configure them for your specific
context, culture, and challenge — that's the “+”.

Twelve ingredients.

Pick two or three.

CUSTOMER FOCUSED

Audience Delight · Aesthetics and Form

PACE AND AGILITY

Speed to Action · Idea Multiplier · Making and Testing · Shape Changing

LEARNING AND DEVELOPMENT

Learning and Mastery · Coaching Through Data · Adventurous Discovery

PERFORMANCE AND FOUNDATION

Raising the Bar · Constraint as Catalyst · Safety Above All



A playground crammed with every piece of equipment is a warehouse.

You choose one to three "+" elements for any given game.
Not twelve. Not all of them.

The configuration depends on your context:

What's the nature of the challenge?

What does your culture need most?

What would actually move things?

What Play+ looks like **at scale**



The question they asked in 2006:

**What if access to all the music ever
made felt better than owning any of it?**

That reframe — from ownership to experience — was a breakthrough. Not a product improvement. A category shift.

Culture first. Commercial breakthrough followed. Eventually.

2024: first annual profit. €1.14 billion. 675 million monthly active users.



Four areas of **impact**

Play creates high-quality **breakthrough solutions**.

Play drives outstanding **commercial success**.

Play **develops critical skills** in an organisation.

Play ramps up employee **engagement**.

**The divide
forming is not
about tools.**

**It is about
conditions.**

The gap is not between organisations that have AI and organisations that don't. It is between people operating in conditions that develop judgment, agency, and craft — and people who aren't.

The time to build the conditions is before you need the breakthrough.

What you can actually do. Starting now.

Protect one pocket.

Find a team, a project, a sprint.
Somewhere you have influence. And
deliberately design the conditions. Player
mindset, genuine autonomy, space to
explore. Run it. See what happens.

Bring one decision back.

Identify something you or your team is
currently outsourcing entirely to AI.
Reclaim the judgment. Not because the
AI is wrong, but because the human
capability matters.

Ask one question.

To someone on your team today: *"When
do you feel most energised at work?"*
Really listen. The answer will tell you
more than any engagement survey.



Individual activity

My Monday move

One action. This week.

THE ESSENTIAL I WANT TO ACTIVATE

Player mindset

Flat by design

Radical transparency

Freedom within form

Space to explore

Blend & build

THE WAREHOUSE CONDITION I WANT TO SHIFT

MY MOVE — SPECIFIC, LOW-COST, THIS WEEK OR NEXT

HOW I'LL KNOW IT HAD AN EFFECT

FROM THE BOOK

The Future of Work is Play

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**How do you change
your work, your
organisation?**

Play at it.

Appendix

A5 size

210 mm

The six essentials *of play*

The playground

TEAM

Player mindset

Everyone is in the game. Not a spectator, not a passenger. Curiosity and collaboration are the entry conditions.

TEAM

Flat by design

Hierarchy suspended during play. Ideas win on merit, not rank. The most junior person can have the best idea.

STAGE

Radical transparency

Information flows freely. No hoarding, no knowledge kept as power. Good ideas emerge when perspectives can meet.

STAGE

Freedom within form

Clear rules and boundaries, but real autonomy within them. Structure enables freedom rather than constraining it.

ACTIVATOR

Space to explore

Dedicated time for experimentation, not just delivery.
Failed ideas become learning. Room to breathe.

ACTIVATOR

Blend & build

Breakthrough emerges when different disciplines, perspectives, and domains collide. Diversity of thought is fundamental.

148 mm

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Your *activity*

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The Play+ Dice Specs



Approximation of dice design

